# Public's explainability preferences AI-powered financial apps

* Required

Welcome

**Thank you for considering participating in this survey.**
The questionnaire is part of the IRP-9 MSCA project at the University of Naples Federico II (UNINA). The goal of the study is to understand how people perceive and prefer different types of explanations provided by artificial intelligence (AI) systems in financial and decision-making contexts.

**What participation involves**
You will be asked to answer questions about your profile, your experience with technology, and your preferences regarding how AI systems explain their results. There are no right or wrong answers. It is important that your responses are sincere.

**Estimated time:** 5-9 minutes.

**Voluntary participation and right to withdraw**

- Participation is completely voluntary.
- You may skip any question or stop completing the questionnaire at any time.
- If you decide to withdraw before submission, your responses will not be recorded.

**Use of data, confidentiality, and UNINA privacy policy**

- Your answers will be anonymized and stored in aggregated form; no personally identifiable data will be published.
- The data will be stored securely, in accordance with European and UNINA regulations on data protection.
- UNINA adopts technical and organizational measures to ensure the security and transparency of data processing.

**Risks and benefits**
There are no direct risks or financial compensations for participation. Your contribution will help develop AI systems that are more transparent and reliable for society and the financial sector.

**Ethical statement**
This study has been reviewed and approved by the Ethics Committee for Research Involving Human Subjects in Biomedical Fields (CERSUB) of the University of Naples Federico II, on September 25, 2025, with reference number PG/2025/0133225.

**ITALIAN:** https://forms.cloud.microsoft/e/uwf3XW5TJz

🇪🇸**SPANISH:** https://forms.cloud.microsoft/e/FJV8GLqKYK
🇫🇷**FRENCH:** https://forms.cloud.microsoft/e/uZjTYMz1t9🇨🇳**CHINESE (TRADITIONAL):** https://forms.cloud.microsoft/e/7ZxAuKttE3**(SIMPLIFIED):** https://forms.cloud.microsoft/e/2CPQatBBp5

Consent
By proceeding to the next page, you confirm that:

- You have read and understood this information;
- You are 18 or older;
- You voluntarily consent to participate in this research under these conditions.

*

◯ Yes

◯ No

You and Artificial Intelligence

I am aware that... *

| | 1 - Not at all familiar | 2 - Slightly familiar | 3 - Fairly familiar | 4 - Familiar | 5 - Very familiar | DON'T |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| ...banks and financial institutions use AI systems to make decisions on loans, credit, and other financial services. | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| ...there are so-called “black box” models in finance, whose decision-making processes are difficult to understand. | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| ...I have the right to request explanations when AI systems make financial decisions that concern me. | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |

| | 1 - Not at all familiar | 2 - Slightly familiar | 3 - Fairly familiar | 4 - Familiar | 5 - Very familiar | DON'T |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| ...the most accurate AI systems often fail to clearly explain their decisions. | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ( |
| ...I am aware of the difference between intrinsically interpretable AI systems and those that only provide approximate explanations after making a decision. | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ( |

On a scale from 0 to 10, which type of AI system in a financial app would you prefer? *

AI systems in financial apps can be very accurate or very easy to understand; but usually not both.

- A more accurate app might make better predictions (like assessing your credit or investments), but it's harder to explain.
- A more explainable app might clearly show why it made a decision, but it can be slightly less precise.

| 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 | 7 | 8 | 9 | 10 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|

**Maximum accuracy (less mistakes)**, even if the app doesn't explain its decisions

Prefer **clear explanations**, even if the app is less accurate

Please select how much you agree with each statement in general. *

| | 1 - Strongly disagree | 2 - Disagree | 3 - Neither disagree nor agree | 4 - Agree | 5 - Strong |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| I am worried about AI being biased against certain groups in financial decisions. | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| I trust that AI systems will make fair financial decisions without human review. | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| There should be stricter regulatons requiring financial services to explain their AI methodology. | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |

| | 1 - Strongly disagree | 2 - Disagree | 3 - Neither disagree nor agree | 4 - Agree | 5 - Strong |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Integrating AI in my finances makes it a better experience overall. | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ |
| This is an attention check. Please select "Disagree" | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ |

Have you used a money manager or investment app that used AI or smart automated tools? *

- ◯ Yes
- ◯ No
- ◯ I am not sure

## Experience with the financial app

Please provide the name or description of the financial sevices platform that you are experienced or familiar with that likely uses AI.

You can also paste the URL.

How would you describe your interaction with the AI-powered financial app? *

Select all that apply.

- [ ] **App user** - I use or am affected by the AI-based financial apps or systems
- [ ] **Creator or developer -** I build, design or train AI systems or models.
- [ ] **Business user -** I use AI tools for finance in my work for decisions or management tasks
- [ ] **Regulator / supervisor -** I work for a public authority or institution overseeing how financial AI systems are used.

Which activit(ies) did you engage in where the app likely made an automated decision (e.g., based on AI or algorithms)? *

- [ ] Approval or rejection of a loan (e.g., credit risk assessment)
- [ ] Calculation of insurance premiums or coverage decisions
- [ ] Flagging or blocking of suspicious transactions (e.g., anti–money laundering decisions)
- [ ] Alerts or blocks for possible fraudulent activities (e.g., fraud detection)
- [ ] Investment recommendations (e.g., stocks or funds)
- [ ] Personalized financial advice (e.g., robo-advisor)
- [ ] Display of sustainability scores or ESG labels on investments
- [ ] Spending alerts or suggestions (e.g., reminders, saving tips)
- [ ] All of the above
- [ ] I don’t know
- [ ] Other

For any of the activities you selected, did the app provide you with an explanation? *

An explanation is any message that helps you understand why a decision was made or how a recommendation was generated by the app. For example:

- “You were approved for this loan based on your credit history”
- “This fund is labeled ‘green’ because it invests in renewable energy”
- “This product is recommended based on your risk profile and sustainability preferences”

- ◯ Yes – I received an explanation
- ◯ No – I did not receive any explanation
- ◯ I am not sure

## Evaluating the Explanation You Received

Only answer this section if you said you received an explanation. Otherwise, you can go back.

Please rate how much you agree with the following statements about the explanation you received. *

*If you did multiple transactions with explanations, please keep in mind the most recent one.*

| | 1 - Strongly disagree | 2 - Disagree | 3 - Neither Disagree nor Agree | 4 - Agree | 5 - Strongly Agree | DON'T |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| The explanation matched my level of knowledge and background. | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ |
| I understood how and why the recommendation was made. | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ |
| The explanation gave me the right amount of detail - not too much, not too little. | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ |
| The explanation helped me judge whether or not to trust the decision. | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ |

How could the explanation have been more helpful or better suited to what you needed or wanted to know?

If the app had provided the improvements you mentioned, how much would your trust in its decision have changed?

| 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 | 7 | 8 | 9 | 10 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|

No change A lot more trust

## Using the app without an explanation

When you use the app, how did you feel about the outcome, recommendation or decision, even without an explanation? *

Select the option that best describes your experience.

- ◯ I trust the recommendation
- ◯ I trusted it somewhat, but I still would have preferred an explanation
- ◯ I was unsure about the recommendation because there was not explanation
- ◯ I did not trust the recommendation at all without an explanation
- ◯ I don't remember

What type of explanation were you hoping to see?

If the app had provided an explanation that matches your preferences, how much would your trust in its decision have changed? *

| 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 | 7 | 8 | 9 | 10 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|

No change A lot more trust

What makes a good explanation?

In which of the following cases do you think an AI system should be *required* to provide an explanation? *

- [ ] Approval or rejection of a loan (e.g., credit risk assessment)
- [ ] Calculation of insurance premiums or coverage decisions
- [ ] Flagging or blocking of suspicious transactions (e.g., anti–money laundering decisions)
- [ ] Alerts or blocks for possible fraudulent activities (e.g., fraud detection)
- [ ] Investment recommendations (e.g., stocks or funds)
- [ ] Personalized financial advice (e.g., robo-advisor)
- [ ] Display of sustainability scores or ESG labels on investments
- [ ] Spending alerts or suggestions (e.g., reminders, saving tips)
- [ ] All of the above
- [ ] I don’t know
- [ ] Other

## How clear the app is about its decisions *

When using a financial app, how important are these aspects to you?

| | Not important at all | Unimportant | Neither important nor unimportant | Important | Very important | DON'T |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| A clear explanation of how the app decided your result *(e.g., how your spending or credit history affected your score)* | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| Knowing the main factors that influenced your result *(e.g., income, spending habits, payment history)* | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |

| | Not important at all | Unimportant | Neither important nor unimportant | Important | Very important | DON'T |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Seeing how your result compares with expert opinions or standard benchmarks *(e.g., market averages or official credit criteria)* | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |

## How much you understand and trust the system *

How important is it for you to understand how the app works and how reliable it is?

| | Not important at all | Unimportant | Neither important nor unimportant | Important | Very important | DON'T |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Seeing how confident or reliable the app's prediction is *(e.g., how certain it is that a transaction is suspicious)* | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| Understanding which parts of the process were automated and which involved a person | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| Learning how errors are detected and corrected by the app *(e.g., when incorrect information affects your account)* | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |

## Knowing who’s responsible *

How important is it for you to know who’s behind the decision?

| | 1 - Not important at all | 2 - Unimportant | 3 - Neither important nor unimportant | 4 - Important | 5 - Very important | DON'T |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Knowing whether a human or an AI made or reviewed the decision *(e.g., loan approval, fraud alert)* | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ |
| Being informed about possible risks or consequences if the AI system makes an error *(e.g., a transaction being blocked by mistake)* | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ |
| This is an attention check. Please select Don't Know. | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ | ◯ |

## How much control or personalization you get *

How important is it for you to feel in control and receive personalized feedback?

| | Not important at all | Unimportant | Neither important nor unimportant | Important | Very important | DON'T |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Getting advice on how to improve or change the outcome *(e.g., how to increase your credit score)* | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| Getting a personalized explanation for your specific case *(e.g., why a certain investment was recommended over another)* | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |
| Knowing how your data is used and protected in the AI system | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ | ○ |

Who should be responsible for ensuring AI systems in finance are transparent? *

- [ ] Financial Institutions
- [ ] Regulatory Bodies and Supervisors
- [ ] Broader society
- [ ] All of the above
- [ ] Other

# About You

Gender *

- ◯ Male
- ◯ Female
- ◯ Non-binary
- ◯ Prefer not to say

Age *

- ◯ 18-24
- ◯ 25-34
- ◯ 35-44
- ◯ 45-54
- ◯ 55-64
- ◯ 65+

Country *

- Afghanistan
- Albania
- Algeria
- Andorra
- Angola
- Antigua and Barbuda
- Argentina
- Armenia
- Australia
- Austria
- Azerbaijan
- Bahamas
- Bahrain

- ◯ Bangladesh
- ◯ Barbados
- ◯ Belarus
- ◯ Belgium
- ◯ Belize
- ◯ Benin
- ◯ Bhutan
- ◯ Bolivia
- ◯ Bosnia and Herzegovina
- ◯ Botswana
- ◯ Brazil
- ◯ Brunei Darussalam
- ◯ Bulgaria
- ◯ Burkina Faso

- ◯ Burundi
- ◯ Cambodia
- ◯ Cameroon
- ◯ Canada
- ◯ Cape Verde
- ◯ Central African Republic
- ◯ Chad
- ◯ Chile
- ◯ China
- ◯ Colombia
- ◯ Comoros
- ◯ Congo (Republic)
- ◯ Congo (Democratic Republic)
- ◯ Costa Rica

- Croatia
- Cuba
- Cyprus
- Czech Republic
- Denmark
- Djibouti
- Dominica
- Dominican Republic
- Ecuador
- Egypt
- El Salvador
- Equatorial Guinea
- Eritrea
- Estonia

- Eswatini
- Ethiopia
- Fiji
- Finland
- France
- Gabon
- Gambia
- Georgia
- Germany
- Ghana
- Greece
- Grenada
- Guatemala
- Guinea

- ◯ Guinea-Bissau
- ◯ Guyana
- ◯ Haiti
- ◯ Honduras
- ◯ Hungary
- ◯ Iceland
- ◯ India
- ◯ Indonesia
- ◯ Iran
- ◯ Iraq
- ◯ Ireland
- ◯ Israel
- ◯ Italy
- ◯ Jamaica

- Japan
- Jordan
- Kazakhstan
- Kenya
- Kiribati
- Kuwait
- Kyrgyzstan
- Laos
- Latvia
- Lebanon
- Lesotho
- Liberia
- Libya
- Liechtenstein

- Lithuania
- Luxembourg
- Madagascar
- Malawi
- Malaysia
- Maldives
- Mali
- Malta
- Marshall Islands
- Mauritania
- Mauritius
- Mexico
- Micronesia
- Moldova

- Monaco
- Mongolia
- Montenegro
- Morocco
- Mozambique
- Myanmar
- Namibia
- Nauru
- Nepal
- Netherlands
- New Zealand
- Nicaragua
- Niger
- Nigeria

- North Korea
- North Macedonia
- Norway
- Oman
- Pakistan
- Palau
- Palestine
- Panama
- Papua New Guinea
- Paraguay
- Peru
- Philippines
- Poland
- Portugal

- ◯ Qatar
- ◯ Romania
- ◯ Russia
- ◯ Rwanda
- ◯ Saint Kitts and Nevis
- ◯ Saint Lucia
- ◯ Saint Vincent and the Grenadines
- ◯ Samoa
- ◯ San Marino
- ◯ Sao Tome and Principe
- ◯ Saudi Arabia
- ◯ Senegal
- ◯ Serbia
- ◯ Seychelles

- ◯ Sierra Leone
- ◯ Singapore
- ◯ Slovakia
- ◯ Slovenia
- ◯ Solomon Islands
- ◯ Somalia
- ◯ South Africa
- ◯ South Korea
- ◯ South Sudan
- ◯ Spain
- ◯ Sri Lanka
- ◯ Sudan
- ◯ Suriname

- Switzerland
- Syria
- Taiwan
- Tajikistan
- Tanzania
- Thailand
- Timor-Leste
- Togo
- Tonga
- Trinidad and Tobago
- Tunisia
- Turkey
- Turkmenistan

- ◯ Uganda
- ◯ Ukraine
- ◯ United Arab Emirates
- ◯ United Kingdom
- ◯ United States of America
- ◯ Uruguay
- ◯ Uzbekistan
- ◯ Vanuatu
- ◯ Vatican City
- ◯ Venezuela
- ◯ Vietnam
- ◯ Yemen
- ◯ Zambia

Which one best describes your job level? *

- ◯ Student / Unemployed
- ◯ Intern / Trainee / Junior Researcher
- ◯ Salaried Employee (Analyst, Associate, etc.)
- ◯ Manager / Coordinator / Supervisor
- ◯ Director / Associate Professor / Head of Unit
- ◯ Executive / Senior Management / Full Professor
- ◯ Other

What is your field of study? *

- ◯ Agricultural, Food, and Forestry Sciences
- ◯ Animal and Veterinary Sciences
- ◯ Architecture and Urban Planning
- ◯ Arts, Music, Design, and Fashion
- ◯ Biological and Life Sciences
- ◯ Biotechnology
- ◯ Business, Economics, and Management
- ◯ Chemical and Physical Sciences
- ◯ Civil, Industrial, and Environmental Engineering
- ◯ Communication and Media Studies
- ◯ Computer and Information Sciences
- ◯ Cultural Heritage and History
- ◯ Education and Training

- ◯ Geography and Environmental Sciences
- ◯ Law and Legal Studies
- ◯ Mathematics and Statistics
- ◯ Philosophy and Humanities
- ◯ Political and Social Sciences
- ◯ Psychology
- ◯ Tourism and Service Management

Which sector do you belong to? *

- ◯ Agriculture, forestry, or fishing
- ◯ Arts, entertainment, sports, or recreation
- ◯ Banking, finance, or insurance
- ◯ Construction or building work
- ◯ Domestic work or household services
- ◯ Education or training
- ◯ Electricity, gas, or energy supply
- ◯ Government, defence, or public administration
- ◯ Health care or social work
- ◯ Hotels, restaurants, or food services
- ◯ International or foreign organizations (e.g., embassies, UN offices)
- ◯ Manufacturing or making products
- ◯ Media, publishing, or broadcasting

- ◯ Mining or quarrying
- ◯ Other personal or community services (e.g., cleaning, beauty, repair)
- ◯ Professional, scientific, or technical services (e.g., consulting, research, design)
- ◯ Real estate or property services
- ◯ Telecommunications or information technology (IT)
- ◯ Transport, delivery, or storage services
- ◯ Water supply, waste, or recycling services
- ◯ Wholesale or retail trade (buying and selling goods)

Highest level of education attained *

- ◯ No formal education
- ◯ Primary education (elementary level)
- ◯ Secondary education (high school or equivalent)
- ◯ Vocational or technical training (non-university certification)
- ◯ Some college or university, no degree
- ◯ Bachelor’s degree (e.g., BA, BSc, BBA)
- ◯ Postgraduate diploma or certificate (after bachelor’s, but not a full degree)
- ◯ Master’s degree (e.g., MA, MSc, MBA)
- ◯ Doctoral degree (PhD or equivalent)
- ◯ Other

(Optional) **Future Research:** If you want to be informed of the survey results or progress of this research, feel free to leave your email below.

Where did you find out about this survey?

*If you received this link from one of our enrolled students at UniMi, please indicate who referred you in the corresponding question within the survey by selecting "OTHER"*

- ◯ MSCA DIGITAL Network
- ◯ Survey Swap/ Survey Circle or similar websites
- ◯ Social Media
- ◯ Friend/Colleague
- ◯ Other

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